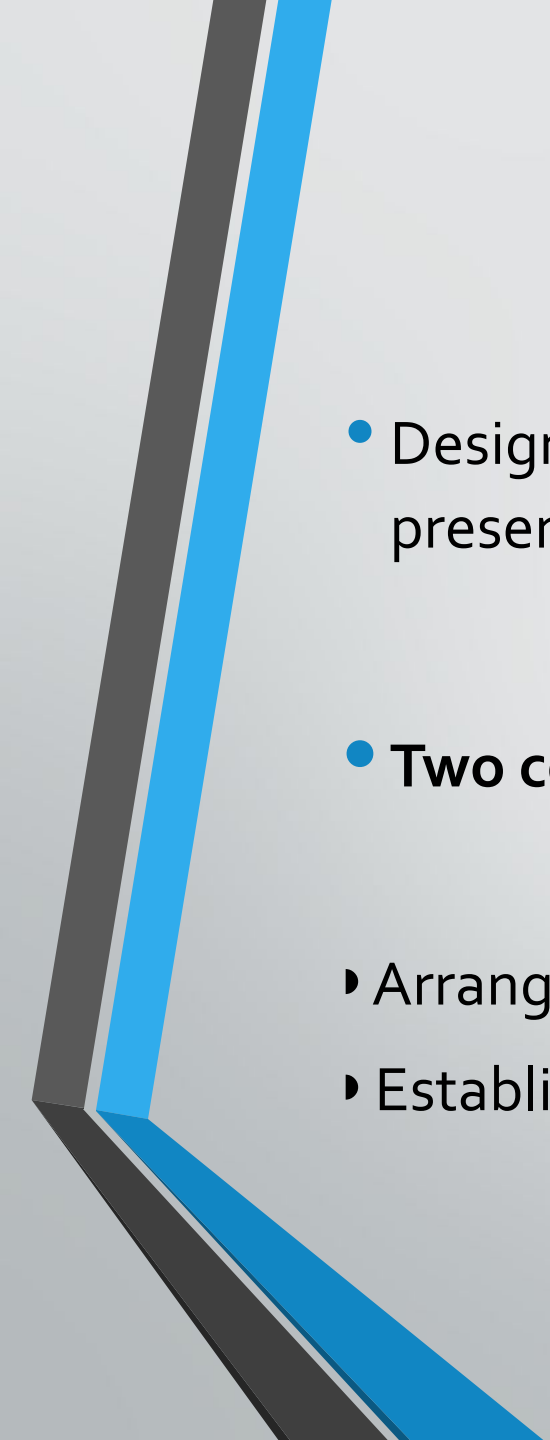




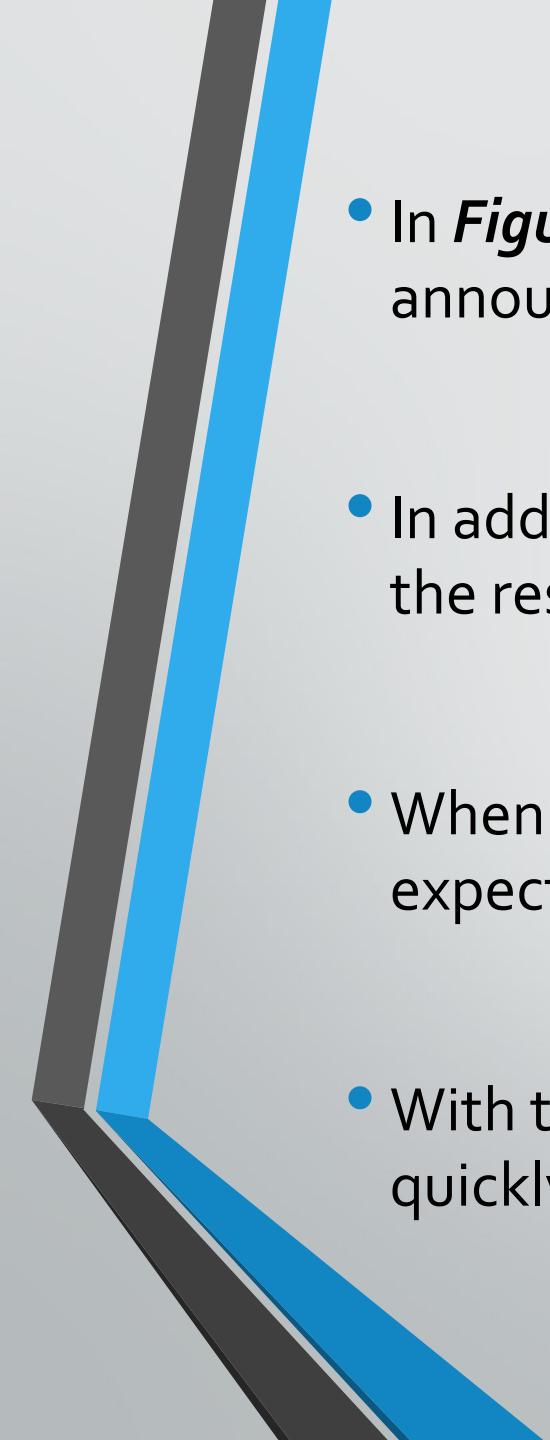
Design the Content

Lecture 5

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- Designing the content means selecting the sequence of the material and presenting it in ways that help the reader grasp it.
 - **Two common methods to use are**
 - Arrange the material top-down
 - Establish a consistent visual logic

Arrange the Material top-Down

- Top-down means putting the main idea first.
- Putting the main idea first establishes the context and the outline of the discussion.

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- In **Figure** on next slide, the entire introduction is the top, because it announces the purpose of the document.
 - In addition, the list at the end of the introduction sets up the organization of the rest of the document.
 - When the reader finishes the first paragraph, she or he has a clear expectation of what will happen in the rest of the message.
 - With this expectation established, the reader can grasp the writer's point quickly

Top

List two major sections of the document

Primary subdivision

Secondary subdivisions

Primary subdivision

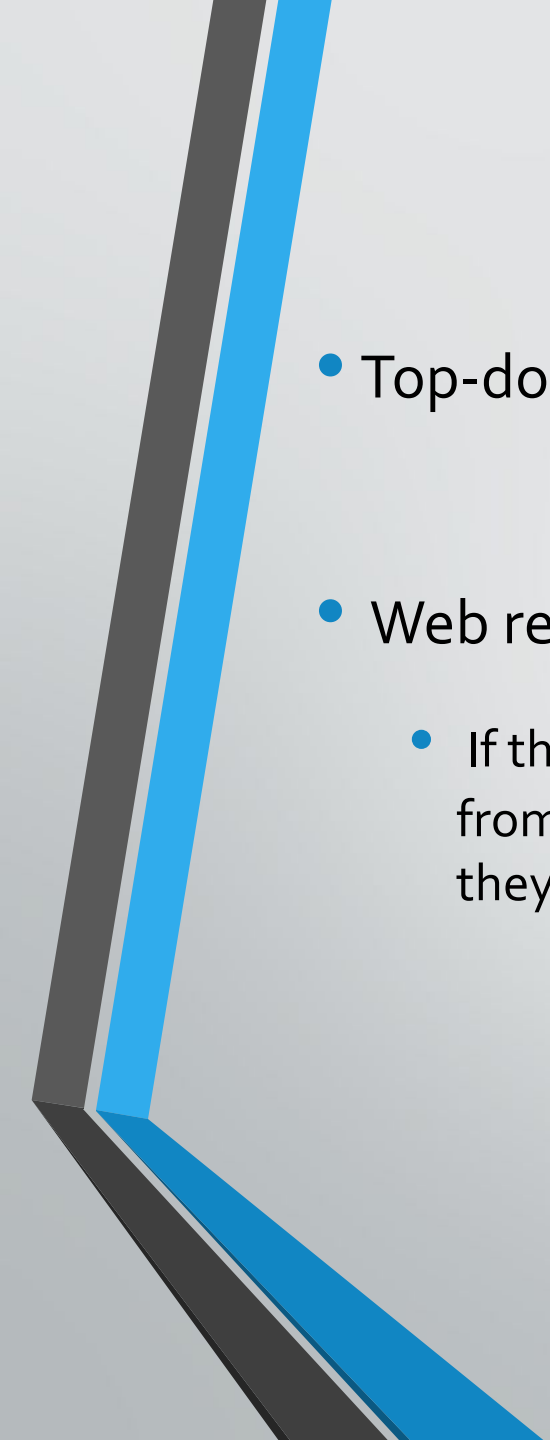
Technical writing is the practical writing that people do on their jobs. The goal of technical writing is to help people get work done. This report explains two key characteristics of technical writing: audience centered and designed.

Audience Centered. Writing is audience centered when it focuses on helping the audience. To help the audience, the writer must help the reader act and must remember community values.

Help Act. Writing helps readers get a job done or increase their knowledge so that they can apply it another time in their job.

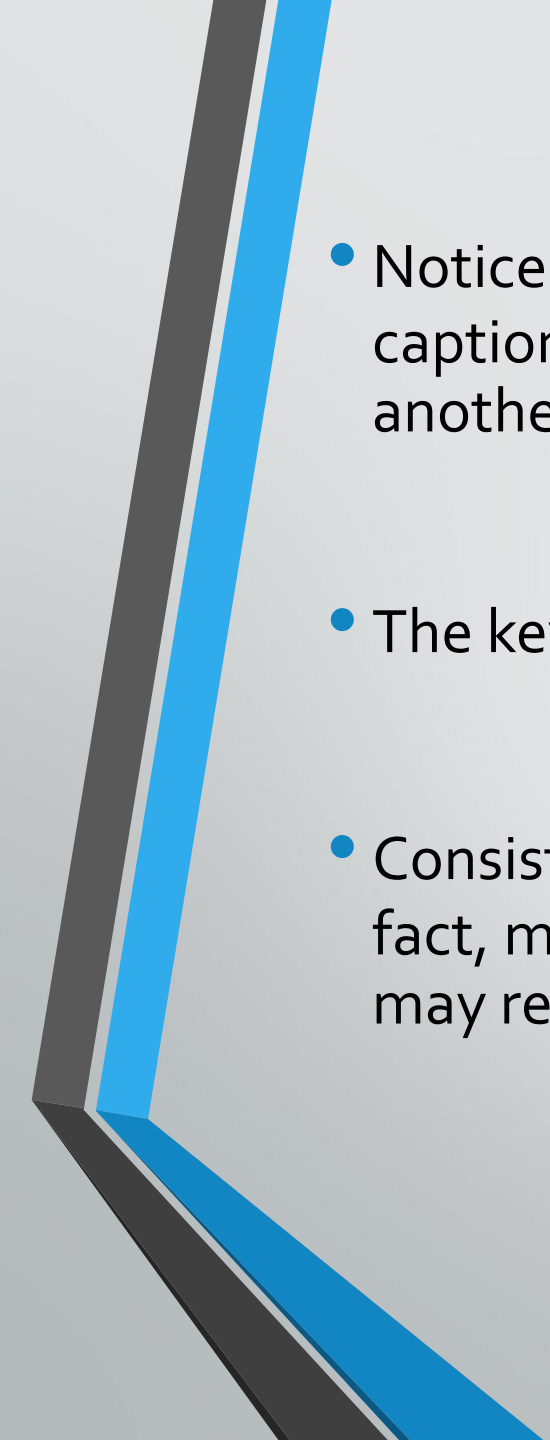
Community Values. Everyone who belongs to any organization agrees with or lives by some of that organization's values. The writer must be sure not to offend those values.

Designed. Technical writing appears in a more designed mode than many other types of writing. Design strategies help readers grasp messages quickly. Three key strategies are the top-down approach, the use of heads, and the use of chunks. Figure 1 illustrates the two methods. The first sentence is the top, or main, idea. The boldfaced words are the heads, which announce topics, and the x's represent the chunks or ideas.

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- Top-down messaging is especially important in Web documents, because
 - Web readers tend to scan information on a page.
 - If they don't see what they're looking for right away, they will often navigate away from your page and find something else that gives them more quickly the information they seek.

Establish a Consistent Visual logic.

- A consistent visual logic means that each element of format is presented the same as other similar elements.
- Notice in **Figure** that the heads that indicate the primary subdivisions (“Audience Centered” and “Designed”) look the same: boldfaced, the first letter of each word capitalized, and placed at the left margin.
- Notice that the heads that indicate the secondary subdivisions (“Help Act” and “Community Values”) also look like each other but differ from the primary heads because they appear indented a half inch.

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- Notice the position of the visual aid, placed at the left margin, and the caption of the visual aid, italicized and in a smaller print size. If there were another visual aid, it would be treated the same way.
 - The key to this strategy is consistency.
 - Consistent treatment of the look helps the reader to grasp your meaning. In fact, many companies and organizations have an official style guide that may require certain standards of formatting.